clever hacker won't leave traces and cause for suspicion. Everything he does is done behind the scenes, and there's no simple way to know if you've been a target. Prevention is the cure again. Though malicious hacking is usually called cracking, crackers prefer the term hackers. Coming to what matters, hacking can be done in two ways:

1 **Locally:** using the same computer which needs to be compromised.
2 **Remotely:** hacking the computer over a network.

FTP server software vulnerabilities

Once your computer is in the wrong hands, well the game is already over. Not so easily though. To hack over a network, the hacker needs to know your IP address. Since most ISPs implement NAT, a basic level of protection is already there. But that's not enough. Hacking over a network requires an exploitable service to be running on your system. For example, if you have FTP server software running on your system and there are known weaknesses in the software, then you're vulnerable to attack. Once again, intelligent rules on your firewall can help with this. In most cases, Windows Firewall has rules potent enough to guard you against intruders. However, it's recommended that you open each service for only those IP ranges from which you expect a connection. For example, if the FTP service is meant for being used only on the home network then you can specify the IP address range in Windows Firewall for which the FTP service should be available.

Keep your friends close, but your enemies closer

Though chances that you would be selected randomly by a malicious hacker are very low (directly proportional to your enemy count), extra precautions never hurt. Some servers such as database servers and web servers can be configured to work only on certain interfaces (e.g. you can disable them for wireless networks). But this solution works in rare cases. On most instance, a more well known program is targeted; for example a vulnerability in day-to-day software such as Firefox, Internet Explorer, Google Talk etc. can allow hackers to take control of your computer. So keep updating them and your OS regularly to have the latest improvements and security.

Phishing

How do you find out if you're being phished? Well, the answer is: keep your eyes open. Phishing tricks you into opening a malicious site designed to